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TRANSPORTATION



Monarch Tractors won't be built by Foxconn after Ohio factory sale

Foxconn will no longer build electric tractors for California startup Monarch Tractor after the Taiwanese tech giant recently sold its Ohio factory to SoftBank.

Monarch CEO Praveen Penmetsa confirmed the news in a [LinkedIn comment](#) Tuesday. He also said his company worked with Foxconn to “build up inventory” before the sale of the factory, noting his startup has “enough to meet customer demand for the next 12 months, along with ample spare parts.”

“In the coming weeks, we will be sharing more about our plans to introduce more Monarch-enabled products in the market through new manufacturing partnerships,” Penmetsa wrote.

Following the sale, SoftBank is expected to work with Foxconn to use the factory to make equipment for the Stargate AI project led by OpenAI and Oracle.

Foxconn purchased the former General Motors factory from EV startup Lordstown Motors in 2022. Young Liu, Foxconn’s chairman, said prior to the sale closing that the facility was going to be the “most important electric vehicle manufacturing and R&D hub in North America.”

Monarch was one of four companies Foxconn promoted as customers (or potential customers) of the electric vehicle contract manufacturing operation it tried to establish at the former General



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Motors factory. Foxconn built a few hundred tractors for Monarch at the plant, but the startup has struggled. Last year, it went through [two rounds of layoffs](#) and had to quickly pivot to new types of customers as California's wine industry crashed.

The other three companies Foxconn wanted to build vehicles for have all filed for bankruptcy. While Foxconn made a handful of Lordstown Motors pickups at the plant, the startup went under in 2023. The other two prospective customers were Fisker Inc. and a small California startup called IndiEV. Foxconn never built any vehicles for those companies at the factory, and they have also both since gone out of business.

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Sean O'Kane

Sr. Reporter, Transportation |

Sean O’Kane is a reporter who has spent a decade covering the rapidly-evolving business and technology of the...

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ENTERPRISE



SoftBank makes \$2B investment in Intel

Kirsten Korosec — 5:23 PM PDT · August 18, 2025

Japanese conglomerate SoftBank has agreed to make a \$2 billion investment in Intel in a deal described as a commitment to advanced technology and semiconductors in the United States.

The agreement, in which SoftBank will buy Intel common stock, [was announced Monday](#) after markets closed. SoftBank will pay \$23 per share of Intel common stock. Shares of Intel, which closed at \$23.66, popped more than 5% in after-hours trading.

SoftBank Group Chairman and CEO Masayoshi Son said in a statement that the “strategic investment reflects our belief that advanced semiconductor manufacturing and supply will further expand in the United States, with Intel playing a critical role.”

The investment provides validation for Intel, which has been overshadowed in recent years by competitors like Nvidia. It also reflects SoftBank’s renewed interest in the U.S., particularly around AI chips. SoftBank recently [purchased a factory](#) in Lordstown, Ohio, owned by Foxconn, as part of a plan to build AI data centers.

Intel, steered by new CEO Lip-Bu Tan, is in the midst of a restructuring that aims to streamline the semiconductor business and focus on its core client and data center portfolio. Earlier this summer, Intel [shuttered its automotive architecture business](#) and laid off most of its staff. It also announced plans to reduce its Intel Foundry division workforce [between 15% and 20%](#).

Tan has also had to navigate political landmines in recent weeks as President Donald Trump [called for his resignation](#) due to conflicts of interest — an accusation that was made without evidence — and his administration reportedly had discussions to [take a stake in Intel](#).

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The SoftBank-Intel deal comes just days after the Trump administration threatened [new tariffs](#) on imported semiconductor chips as part of his strategy to boost domestic production.



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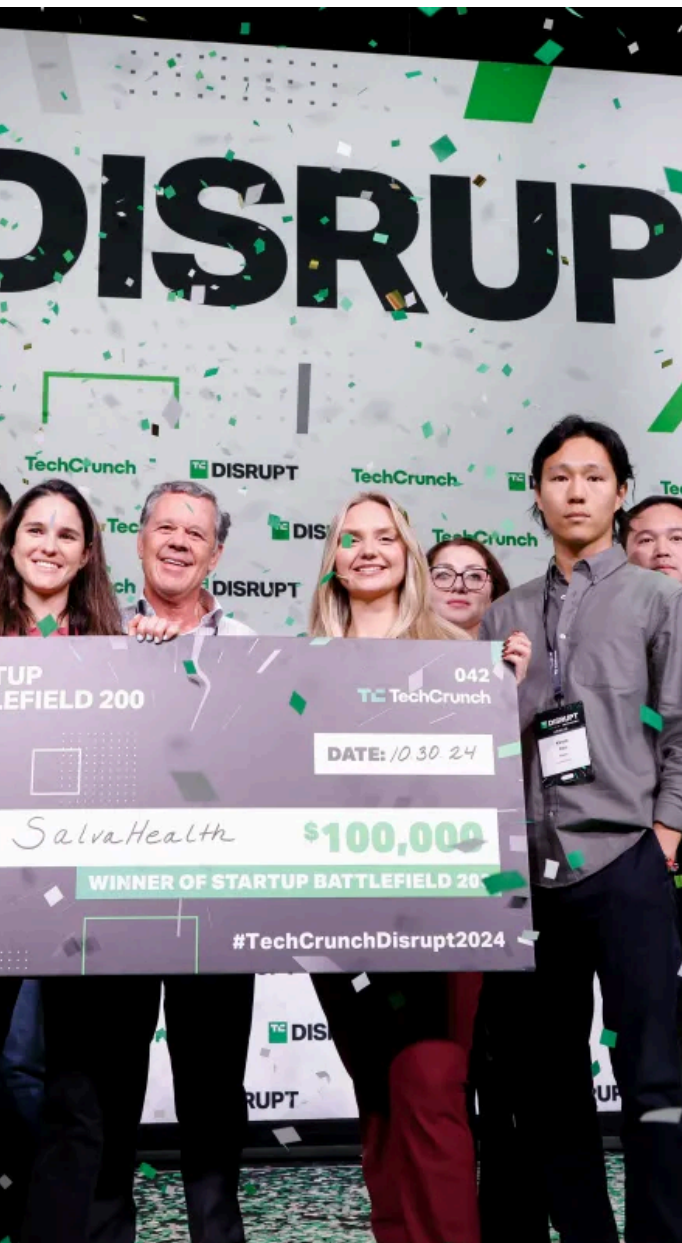


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STARTUPS

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The wait is almost over: The 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list drops August 27

Isabelle Johannessen — 9:22 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Set your alarms. Bookmark this page. Refresh like your future depends on it.

After reviewing thousands of groundbreaking applications from around the globe, TechCrunch is just days away from announcing the 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 — our handpicked cohort of the most promising early-stage startups set to take the stage at [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) this October 27-29.

The 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list will go live, right here, on Wednesday, August 27, at 9:00 a.m. PT.

Whether you applied, referred a standout founder, or just want to see who made the cut, this is the moment you've been waiting for. Your name. Your rival. Your next investment. They might all be on this list.

This October marks 20 years that [TechCrunch Disrupt](#) has been shaping the startup world — and we're pulling out all the stops. For two decades, the biggest names in tech, venture capital, and startups have taken our stage to share their visions and make history. Game-changers like Dropbox, Cloudflare, Fitbit, and Discord got their start in [Startup Battlefield](#) — and this is where the next generation of breakout companies will be born.

Want to see these rising stars pitch live? Hear from top-tier founders and investors? Network with the people shaping the future of tech? [Grab your ticket to Disrupt 2025](#), happening October 27-29 in San Francisco.

Last year's winner, [Salva Health](#), topped a competitive field of startups with its development of a portable device to detect breast cancer early, especially in rural populations that lack access to mammograms and other diagnostic tools. You can relive their victory below, [listen to our Equity](#)

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The wait is almost over: The 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list drops August 27

Isabelle Johannessen
- 23 hours ago

[podcast interview with CEO Valentina Agudelo](#), or [get a detailed rundown of their journey here](#).



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Announcing the winner of Startup Battlefield ...



Salva was far from alone. Out of the cohort of 200 trailblazing startups, TechCrunch editorial selected the [2024 Top 20 finalists](#) who wowed the crowd with their disruptive innovations, live demos, and perfected pitches. Runner-up [geCKo Materials](#) [turned heads with its compelling story](#) about how years of research led to a breakthrough innovation in adhesive materials that is disrupting the Velcro industry one impossibly sticky situation at a time.

This year's Startup Battlefield 200 Top 20 finalists will be revealed on Day 1 of Disrupt 2025 (Monday, October 27). You don't want to miss the chance to see these founders battle it out live onstage for the \$100,000 prize and Disrupt Cup. Your incumbent will be there. Your competitors have registered. Don't get left behind — [get your tickets to Disrupt 2025](#).

Mark your calendars and set your alarms — the 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list drops right here on Wednesday, August 27, at 9:00 a.m. PT. Be the first to see which exceptional startups made the cut.

Startup Battlefield is proudly presented by Google Cloud, our premier sponsor.



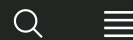
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CLIMATE



Aalo Atomics raises \$100M to build a microreactor and data center together

Tim De Chant — 8:41 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

Nuclear startups have been soaking up attention from hyperscalers and cash from investors. Aalo

Atomics is the latest beneficiary of the big tech-small nuclear love affair, raising \$100 million in a Series B, the company announced today.

The startup plans to flip the switch on its first reactor in the summer of 2026, CEO Matt Loszak [said](#) in a LinkedIn post. The facility will be located on the campus of the Idaho National Laboratory.

Aalo — not to be confused with the [defunct furniture startup](#) — could be considered a pseudo-spinout of the Department of Energy lab, which developed and open-sourced a small modular reactor design called Marvel. The company’s CTO, Yasir Arafat, previously led Marvel’s design, which Aalo says “inspired” its prototype. Aalo also received [development support](#) from the Idaho National Lab as part of an Obama administration program to accelerate nuclear reactor development.

The Series B round was led by Valor Equity Partners with participation from 50Y, Alumni Ventures, Crescent Enterprises, Crosscut, Fine Structure Ventures, Gaingels, Harpoon Ventures, Hitachi Ventures, Kindred Ventures, MCJ, NRG Energy, Nucleation Capital, Perpetual VC, Tishman Speyer, and Vamos Ventures.

If Aalo can meet its aggressive deadline, it would buck a trend in the nuclear industry, which has a history of long timelines compounded by delays.

Like many advanced nuclear startups, Aalo is counting on economies of scale to help rein in both costs and build times. If the company can prove its approach works, it says it will build thousands of Aalo Pod power plants, which will consist of five Aalo-1 reactors delivering heat to a single turbine to generate a total of 50 megawatts of electricity.

The startup says that the Aalo-X prototype will also have an “experimental” data center built next door,

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a detail that sounds more like a marketing ploy than a technological innovation.



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Ultimately, Aalo says it aims to deliver electricity at three cents per kilowatt-hour, a price that would [make it competitive](#) with new natural gas power plants and solar farms built today. The startup hasn't put a timeline on that price, though, a wise move given the nuclear industry's [previous promises](#).

Aalo isn't the only nuclear startup making news this week. Yesterday, Kairos said that the Tennessee Valley Authority agreed to buy 50 megawatts of generating capacity from its Hermes 2 power plant, which the startup is planning to build in Oak Ridge, Tennessee. Google, in turn, will use that power to drive its data centers.

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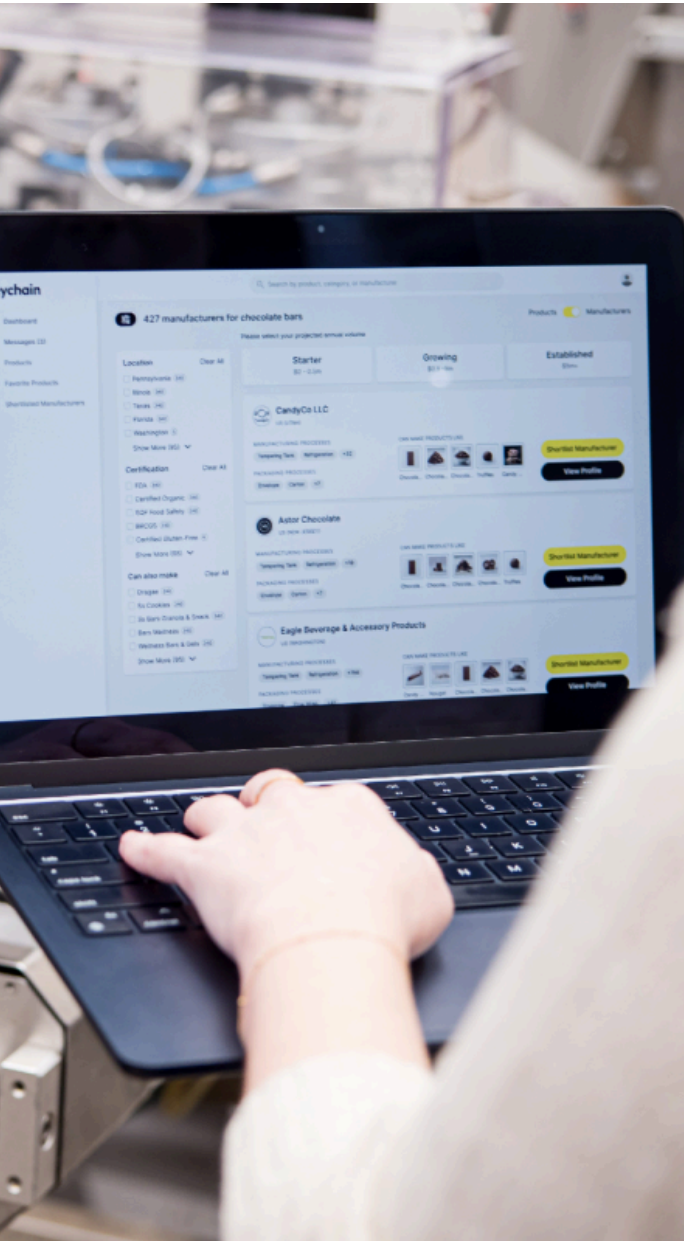
Tim De Chant

Senior Reporter, Climate |

Tim De Chant is a senior climate reporter at TechCrunch. He has written for a wide range of publications, including...

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ENTERPRISE



CPG startup Keychain
snags \$30M to build in
India, grow in the U.S.

Jagmeet Singh — 7:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

[Keychain](#), a U.S. startup that [helps consumer brands find manufacturing partners](#), has raised \$30 million in fresh funding as it looks to scale its India-based development team to drive growth in North America.

While headquartered in New York, Keychain operates as a distributed company with its core engineering and product development centered in India. The startup is doubling down on this model with the new funding, aiming to grow its engineering, product design, and analytics teams in Gurugram from 35 to 70 in the coming months, and to around 100 within a year. This India-based team already represents half of Keychain’s 70-person global headcount, with about 20 employees in New York and the remainder in Austin, handling partnerships, go-to-market, and sales.

The strategy is deliberate. Despite only serving Western markets, Keychain has built its primary development operations in in Gurugram — which is the country’s second-largest tech hub after Bengaluru — to develop its consumer packaged goods (CPG) platform for clients in North America. The software platform already helps eight of the top 10 retailers, including 7-Eleven and Whole Foods, and seven of the top CPG brands, such as General Mills, connect with potentially suitable manufacturers, according to the startup. So why India?

“It’s the talent, depth, availability, and the speed with which you can access talent of that depth and availability [in India],” said Oisin Hanrahan, co-founder and CEO of Keychain, in an interview.

Hanrahan co-founded Keychain in 2023 with Umang Dua — his co-founder at Handy, a home services software startup later acquired by Angi — and Jordan Weitz. Dua, who is originally from New Delhi,

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has been a “natural advantage” in building Keychain’s core teams in Gurugram, Hanrahan said.



KEYCHAIN CO-FOUNDERS JORDAN WEITZ, OISIN HANRAHAN, AND UMANG DUA (LEFT TO RIGHT)

IMAGE CREDITS:KEYCHAIN

Both Hanrahan and Dua spent time structuring Keychain’s teams across India and the U.S., ultimately choosing India as the company’s engineering hub. The decision was shaped by their experience at Handy and Angi, where they found it challenging to build a “sustainable, enduring” engineering team in the U.S.

“We’ve thought about engineering as: how do we build a core, sustainable engineering organization that can get to scale reasonably quickly, that has endurance, that’s got deep talent pools, and AI exposure that can take on real, important challenges, that’s commercially minded? And we looked at where we had those teams before, when we were at Handy and Angi, and obviously, India is just an amazing location and really checks a lot of those boxes,” Hanrahan told TechCrunch.



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Several U.S. startups, [especially those developing SaaS solutions](#), base their engineering and product teams in cities like Bengaluru, Gurugram, and Noida. In recent months, the country has also seen a [wave of multinational companies establishing offshore hubs](#), often referred to as global capability centers. But unlike most of these firms — which also target Indian consumers even as many say [India is harder to sell into](#) — Keychain stands apart. It more closely resembles companies like the UK's [Deliveroo](#) and Southeast Asia's [Gojek](#) and [Grab](#) — all of which tap into India's tech talent for product development and R&D without having a market presence in the country.

“India's position as a global technology hub has made it a compelling destination for product development, even for startups that have no direct business in the country,” said Neha Singh, co-founder of the Bengaluru-based private market intelligence platform Tracxn, in an interview with TechCrunch.

India's time zone also allows teams to work beyond U.S. hours, enabling near-continuous development cycles, Singh added.

KeychainOS as the next big thing coming from Indian talent

Keychain plans to use its India team not only to improve its current platform — launched in February 2024 and used by over 20,000 brands and retailers to find manufacturing partners — but also to build new AI-powered software that helps manufacturers manage their product cycles more efficiently and with better oversight.

Called KeychainOS, the software will have four modules, with the first one already available. This module helps manufacturers comply with their food safety requirements, using AI to take quantitative data and convert it into a qualitative report that can be shared with auditors. The software can also pull data using natural language when an auditor requests a specific insight, Hanrahan told TechCrunch.

The other three modules of the software will focus on purchasing and procurement, inventory, and production planning, the executive noted.

The OS offering will compete with traditional ERP systems like Oracle, QAD, and Plex, which require add-ons like TraceGains and Redzone to be usable for manufacturers, the startup said.

In addition to its KeychainOS for manufacturers, Keychain has embedded AI into its search and discovery layer to help retailers quickly find relevant third-party manufacturers for their products.

KEYCHAIN'S SEARCH AND DISCOVERY LAYER WITH AN AI
INTEGRATION

IMAGE CREDITS:KEYCHAIN

Keychain already helps brands and retailers find third-party manufacturers in food, beverage, supplements, health, and beauty categories and is looking to expand its platform to pet and household products later this year.

Currently, the startup serves businesses in the U.S. and Canada and is [aiming to enter Europe](#) later this year.

While the startup offers its software free to brands and retailers, manufacturers pay to access the platform and get discovered. KeychainOS provides them with another reason to engage.

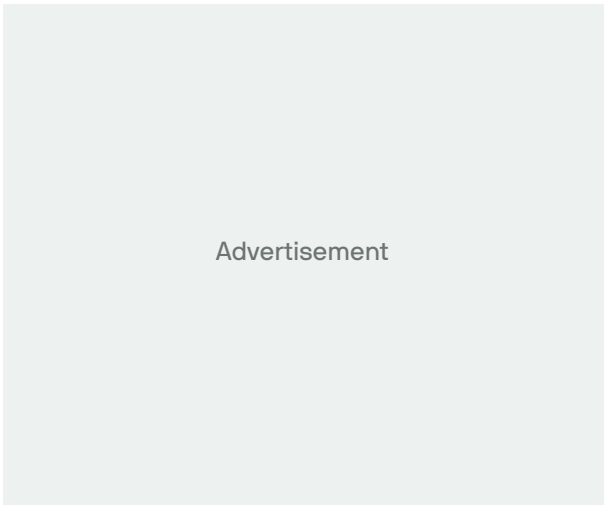
Keychain already has over 30,000 manufacturers on its platform, with “hundreds and hundreds” paying to use it. These customers pay anywhere from \$10,000 to over \$100,000, Hanrahan said, adding that the startup earns around \$20,000 per manufacturer annually on average.

Keychain's Series B round was led by Wellington Management and existing investor BoxGroup, alongside other existing investors. With this funding, the startup has raised \$68 million in total. Of that, Hanrahan told TechCrunch that the startup still has over \$50 million in the bank.

The startup had a post-money valuation of \$260 million in its last round of \$15 million in November 2024. Hanrahan did not disclose the current valuation but said it was a “good step up.”

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Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for...

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